



Mother-Teen Conversations About Sex and Relationships: A Qualitative Study in Rural Latino Communities

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Abstract

Parent-teen communication about sex and relationships supports healthy decision-making and well-being among teens. However, interpersonal communication is affected by specific cultural and place-based contexts. These sensitive conversations may be particularly challenging for families in rural and Latino communities due to limited sexual health knowledge and information, stigma, embarrassment, and social norms. Using a systems approach to interpersonal communication, this study aimed to explore communication around sensitive topics including sex, sexual health, dating, and relationships among mothers and teens living in predominately Latino rural communities. Nineteen mother-teen dyads (38 individuals) participated in semi-structured interviews in English or Spanish in rural Fresno County, California. Interviews were transcribed in the original language, coded, and analyzed thematically. Results found that all but one teen was satisfied or somewhat satisfied with their discussions about dating and sex with their parents, compared to a third of the mothers. Most mothers and teens reported discussing these topics, although conversations about dating were more common than about sex, which was often viewed as stressful and awkward by teens. Many mothers felt unprepared to initiate these conversations due to cultural norms, embarrassment, and insufficient knowledge. Teens valued informative, open, and non-judgmental discussions that address both positive and negative aspects of sex and dating. Findings suggest that while mothers and teens are willing to engage in these conversations, they need additional tools and resources. Programs that incorporate culturally relevant discussions on intergenerational influences, gender norms, and communication strategies may help strengthen mother-teen dialogue and improve adolescent sexual health outcomes.

Keywords: Family communication · Sexual health · Adolescent · Qualitative research · Rural · Hispanic

Highlights

- Latino mothers and their teens in rural California discussed how they communicate about sex and relationships.
- Discussions about dating and relationships were more common than discussions about sex.
- Many mothers struggled to find the right words to discuss these topics and wanted more information.
- Teens stressed the importance of their parents listening better and being non-judgmental.

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Parent-teen communication about sex, sexual health, dating, and relationships supports the development of teens' decision-making skills and emotional well-being. Such conversations can advance teens' ability to make better-informed decisions about sex and relationships, navigate complex emotional and social situations, and develop a strong sense of self (Coakley et al., 2017; Flores & Barroso, 2017; Hicks et al., 2013; Lemieux et al., 2010). Communication about and openness to discussing sensitive topics has been shown to lead to safer sexual behaviors among youth, such as the use of contraception and condoms, and decreased risk of

unintended pregnancy (Rusley et al., 2022; Widman et al., 2016).

Despite their importance, conversations around sex and relationships remain difficult for many families. This interpersonal communication is influenced at the macro-level by community and cultural context and at the micro-level by family member dynamics (Dainton & Zelle, 2005). Bowen's Family Systems Theory describes the family as an emotional unit and suggests that these conversations are influenced by generational transmission of values and by roles within the family unit (Bowen, 1993). In the context of parent-teen communication about sex, these family dynamics shape the information conveyed, impacting teens' understanding and decision-making. Commonly reported barriers include parents' limited knowledge about sexuality and sexual health, the belief that their children were not ready to have these conversations, personal embarrassment, and cultural and social norms, such as holding conservative and religious beliefs (Malacane & Beckmeyer, 2016). As a result, occurrences of parent-teen communication are often limited, usually taking place in a single conversation in early adolescence (Flores & Barroso, 2017; Padilla-Walker, 2018; Padilla-Walker et al., 2020).

Systems of interpersonal communication are also affected by specific cultural and place-based contexts. Several studies have focused on Latino families and the role of cultural values in communication around sexual health (Caal et al., 2013; Estrada-Martínez et al., 2021; Guilamo-Ramos et al., 2008; Matsuda et al., 2022). Matsuda et al. (2022) described how four common Hispanic cultural values — *familismo*, honoring family, *machismo*, dominant masculinity, *marianismo*, traditional female gender roles, and *respeto*, obedience to a person of higher status — influence the belief that sex is not an appropriate topic of discussion and perpetuate traditional gender roles in dating and relationships. These cultural influences often result in gender-specific expectations and discussions about sex with children (Alcalde & Quelopana, 2013; Stauss et al., 2011). Prior research with adolescent and young adult Latinos reflect these traditional norms, finding that a desire to please parents, generational differences, and a taboo around sex made open communication with parents challenging (Barral et al., 2020; Caal et al., 2013). Historically, parent-teen communication about sex has been less common among Latino families in the U.S. relative to other racial/ethnic groups, although rates appear to be increasing in recent years (Lantos et al., 2019; Widman et al., 2014). While one study found that 80% of Latino middle school students in the Northeastern and Southwestern U.S. listed parents as their primary source of sexual health information (Fuxman et al., 2015), only 38% of Latino 9th grade students in Los Angeles reported this (Eversole et al., 2017).

At the macro level, rural communities embody a distinct context for interpersonal communication due to social, structural, economic, cultural, political, and geographic factors (Bishop et al., 2025). These factors frequently pose challenges to adolescent sexual and reproductive health, resulting in higher rates of unintended pregnancies, lower use of contraception, and increasing rates of sexually transmitted infections (STIs) (Sutton et al., 2019). Youth in rural communities have limited access to health services and transportation, lower insurance coverage, and often live in areas of highly concentrated poverty (Crouch et al., 2024; Probst et al., 2018). Rural adolescents frequently report concern about their privacy when seeking services and are less likely to report awareness or use of family planning services compared to their urban counterparts (Miller et al., 2018; Yarger et al., 2017). Similarly, local attitudes and policies influence the sexual health education provided in schools (Walker et al., 2021). While about half of adolescents in the U.S. receive comprehensive sexual health education, differences in the content and quality persist by location, sex, and race/ethnicity, with rural adolescents less likely to report learning about contraceptive methods or where to receive them (Lindberg et al., 2016).

These macro-level factors associated with rurality interact with Latino culture and values to influence interpersonal communication at the family level. Few studies have assessed the specific context of sexual health communication among Latino families in rural communities (de Leon Siantz et al., 2017; Stauss et al., 2011), although some have focused on Latino families in urban areas (Estrada-Martínez et al., 2021; Eversole et al., 2017; Fuxman et al., 2015). A small study exploring parent-teen communication from the perspective of rural parents in California found that challenges to conversations about sex included parents' limited knowledge on the subject, perceptions of their teens' attitudes, time constraints, generation gaps, and embarrassment (de Leon Siantz et al., 2017).

The limited research on parent-teen communication among rural Latino families underscores the need to engage youth and their parents to better understand their perspectives and the challenges faced when engaging in sensitive conversations. Using a systems approach to interpersonal communication, this study aims to explore communication around sensitive topics including sex, sexual health, dating, and relationships among mothers and teens living in predominately Latino communities in rural Fresno County, California. By interviewing dyads of mothers and their teens, this study can compare experiences and concerns, recognize points of divergence, and identify potential leverage points and recommendations for improvement.

Methods

Setting

This study was developed as part of the **Rural Education and Development for Youth (READY)** project, a federally funded initiative to develop and implement a systems-thinking approach to sexual health education and services for youth in rural communities of Fresno County, California. The project offered multiple activities including the replication of an evidence-based sexual health education curriculum, a supplemental sexual health education curriculum for older students, educational workshops for parents and caregivers, and professional learning opportunities for school staff. READY was conducted in partnership with two community organizations, Fresno County Superintendent of Schools and Fresno Economic Opportunities Commission. Fresno County is the second largest agricultural producing region in the state and the country (Cregan, 2022). The majority of youth and families in these communities are Latino immigrants from Mexico and Central America (Fresno City, 2023). These communities have higher than average rates of teen births and STIs as well as school dropout, unemployment, and poverty (California Department of Health, 2022). The rural communities in this study had a median household income ranging from \$46,458–\$47,594, with approximately one-third of families living below the poverty level (U.S. Census Bureau, 2023).

Participants and Recruitment

Participants in this study were recruited as **dyads, defined as one parent or caregiver and one teen from the same family**. Teens were eligible if they were aged 13–19, lived in a rural community of Fresno County, and spoke English or Spanish. Parents or caregivers (hereafter referred to as parents) were eligible if they lived in a rural community and spoke English or Spanish. Researchers identified potential participants through community partners and referrals from other respondents (i.e., snowball sampling). Parents were invited to participate with one of their eligible teen children, without gender-specific requirements for dyad composition. Researchers then contacted interested individuals by phone to explain the study, answer questions, and schedule interviews. **A total of 40 interviews were conducted with 20 dyads**. Despite recruitment efforts, **only one dyad included a father**. We excluded that dyad from this analysis to more specifically reflect mother-teen communication about sex and relationships; thus, this analysis includes interviews with **19 mother/teen dyads** ($N = 38$).

Study Instruments

We developed **separate semi-structured interview guides with the intent of gathering teens' and parent perspectives on their communication with one another about sensitive topics**. The interview guide was informed by research with similar populations (Murray et al., 2014; Stauss et al., 2011), incorporating established qualitative research methodologies while also integrating additional questions tailored to our study's specific objectives and population. The interview guides were **pilot-tested and modified accordingly**. Each was available in **both English and Spanish**. The interview guide for teens asked them to reflect on their family dynamics and communication with their parents around sensitive topics including sex, sexual health, dating, and relationships. Teen interviews ranged from 15–60 min and averaged **23 min** in length, excluding the assent process. The interview guide for mothers paralleled the teen interview guide. If the mothers had multiple teens, they were asked to speak to their communication specifically with the teen who participated in the study. Interviews with mothers ranged from 17–60 min and averaged **30 min** in length.

Respondents completed a short survey asking questions about their socio-demographic characteristics prior to the interviews. The study protocol was approved by the Institutional Review Board of the University of California, San Francisco.

Data Collection

Four members of the research team conducted interviews with dyads between August 2022 and June 2023. **All interviewers are public health professionals with training in qualitative methodologies**; one was a trained health educator, and one had medical training. Three interviewers were female, and one was male. The research team acknowledges that our backgrounds, language abilities, and positionality as researchers external to the community may have influenced data collection and analysis. Prior to the interviews, the researchers introduced themselves, discussed the purpose and process of the study, and provided written consent materials in both English and Spanish. Minor teens provided assent, and mothers provided consent for themselves and their minor children. Teens' and mothers' interviews were conducted one-on-one to maintain confidentiality. Interviews were conducted in English or Spanish according to the preference of the respondent. Two bilingual interviewers had the same level of fluency in both languages. All teen interviews were conducted in English. Of 19 mothers, 15 interviews were conducted in Spanish and four in English. Eight dyads were interviewed in

person, and 11 dyads were interviewed via Zoom or by phone, according to the preference of the respondent. At the end of the interview, mothers received a sheet of local resources and information on parent-teen communication. Teens received a \$30 gift card and mothers received a \$35 gift card for their participation.

All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim in Spanish or English. The interviews conducted in English were transcribed using Otter.ai. and the interviews conducted in Spanish were transcribed using AmberScript and reviewed by Spanish-speaking research staff.

Analysis

We utilized a hybrid approach to thematic analysis including both deductive coding based on the interview guides and inductive coding of themes that were identified in the interviews (Dey, 1999). Coding was conducted using Dedoose qualitative data management software, and analysis was conducted using Microsoft Excel. All interviews were coded in the original language. One researcher coded all the interviews conducted in English. Two researchers coded interviews conducted in Spanish. A subset of interviews were double-coded by the researchers to ensure inter-coder reliability; analysis yielded a Cohen's kappa coefficient of 0.84, indicating strong agreement between coders. Discrepancies were resolved through discussion and agreement on final coding allocation. Researchers identified relationships in each code and across codes and extracted relevant themes. Sub-codes were developed based on the themes that emerged from analysis. The dyadic analysis was conducted based on the themes and subthemes for the mother-teen pair. Researchers explored the agreement and variation in responses within and between pairs (Collaço et al., 2021).

To enhance the trustworthiness of the key findings, direct quotations were selected based on the ability to illustrate key themes, provide direct perspectives, and capture participants' experiences (Eldh et al., 2020). The perspectives of all participants contributed to the thematic analyses, even if not directly quoted. All Spanish quotations were translated by one bilingual researcher and verified by a second bilingual researcher.

Results

Participant Characteristics

Of the 19 mother-teen dyads who participated in interviews, virtually all mothers and teens identified as Latino, and most identified as Catholic. The average age of teen participants was 15.3 years (range: 13–19). The average age of the

mothers was 41.6 years (range: 33–52). Slightly over half (53%) of the teens were male. Most teens (90%) and all mothers identified as straight or heterosexual. Most teens spoke Spanish and English at home while most mothers spoke Spanish at home. Most mothers were employed in the agricultural or educational sectors, and most of their spouses were employed in agriculture. See Table 1.

Key Themes

We identified several key themes in the interviews about mother-teen communication: (1) levels of satisfaction with communication, (2) discussions around dating and relationships, (3) conversations about sex and sexual health, and (4) communication challenges. Participants also provided recommendations for improving communication. In several instances, we found diverging perspectives between the teens and their mothers. However, we note that the teens and mothers emphasized different points based on their own experiences and expertise. For example, teens spoke more often about dating rules, whereas the mothers were more likely to discuss the role of culture and their own experiences. In general, the mothers also provided more detailed responses to the questions; this is reflected in the presentation of results.

Satisfaction with Communication

Overall satisfaction with conversations about sex and dating varied across mothers and teens and by topic. All but one teen stated that they were satisfied or somewhat satisfied with their discussions about dating and sex with their parents, compared to a third of mothers. Only one teen reported being unsatisfied with their communication compared to five mothers, suggesting that some mothers may perceive the discussions as insufficient even when the teens find them acceptable. When comparing satisfaction within dyads, six were concordant with both the mother and teen stating that they were satisfied or somewhat satisfied with their communication. Ten dyads were discordant in their levels of satisfaction. While there is some alignment in perceptions of conversation satisfaction, there are notable discrepancies in how mothers and teens perceive these discussions.

Several mothers discussed being unsatisfied due to lack of communication, wanting to have more conversations with their teen. As one mother stated, “*Well, he barely talks to me, he doesn’t trust me. I try to talk to him.*” (Mother, Dyad 6, age 44) However, her son stated, “*It’s good,*” when asked about their satisfaction with communication. (Male Child, Dyad 6, age 14) Satisfaction also sometimes varied by the topic and the particular parent. One teen ranked conversations on a scale of one to ten:

Table 1 Sociodemographic characteristics of participants

Characteristic		Teens (n = 19)	%	Mothers (n = 19)	%
Gender	Male	10	53	0	0
	Female	9	47	19	100
Sexual Orientation	Heterosexual/Straight	17	89	19	100
	Gay/Lesbian, Bisexual, Other	0	0	0	0
	Prefer Not to Say	2	11	0	0
Religion	Catholic	15	79	17	89
	Christian	0	0	2	11
	Not sure	1	5	0	0
	None	3	16	0	0
Race/Ethnicity	Hispanic/Latino	19	100	18	95
	White	0	0	1	5
Language Spoken at Home	English	1	5	2	11
	Spanish	5	26	11	58
	Spanish and English	13	68	6	32
Highest Level of Schooling	No Schooling Completed	0	0	1	5
	Primary School (Elementary, Middle)	4	21	3	16
	High School	15	79	10	53
	Associate's Degree or Above	0	0	5	26
Number of Children	1–3	0	0	11	58
	4–6	0	0	8	42
Marital Status	Single, never married			2	11
	Married or domestic partnership			17	89
	Widowed, Divorced, Separated			0	0
Employment Status	Employed			12	63
	Not Employed			7	37
Employment Type of Spouse	Agriculture			12	63
	Other			3	16

About dating, it's about an eight. About sex, it's like a three. I don't really like to talk about it with [my mom]. With my dad, my dad does speak more about it because he is more open. He's like, ... 'Are you sexually active?' and I actually am honest with him. Because he like, you know, he's open about it. Like he's straight up. ... he's not gonna give me trouble. ... So, I think I am more open about it with my dad than with my mom. (Female Child, Dyad 9, age 17)

Dating and Relationships

The majority of teens and mothers stated that they had discussed dating and relationships with each other. However, about a fifth of teens said that they had not discussed dating and relationships with their parents, though their mothers replied that they had. Four sub-themes emerged related to conversations about dating and

relationships: (1) healthy and unhealthy relationships, (2) dating rules and expectations, (3) differences in communication about dating, and (4) strategies for communicating about dating.

A few teens mentioned they would like to have more in-depth conversations about dating and relationships while two teens reported already being very open with their parents. For example, one explained what they talked about:

Like everything. Like I'm really open with them... If I feel like if something's off with my girlfriend, like, I'll tell them and then they'll help me or anything, like any little thing. I'll tell them and they're always there to help me or answer my question. (Male Child, Dyad 7, age 16)

Another teen explained the types of topics discussed with her parents as “*like what to expect in a relationship, the dangers of dating, and also dangers of having sex.*”

Basically, just the dangers and the good side of doing both of them.” (Female Child, Dyad 1, age 14)

Healthy Relationships

Many teens and mothers reported talking about different aspects of healthy or unhealthy relationships. A third of the teens reported that their parents told them to be respectful of the person they were dating and explained how to treat the other person. A few teens also mentioned that their parents advised them not to stay in abusive relationships. One reflected that her parent said, *“If they’re, like, downgrading you, don’t stay in that relationship; leave it.”* (Female Child, Dyad 18, age 17)

A few mothers also mentioned discussing healthy versus abusive relationships. One used her experience with domestic violence as an example in advising her daughter:

The first time I was married, I suffered domestic violence and that, you know, that doesn’t go away, and I think that’s why I take care of her. I feel that I overprotect her so that the same thing doesn’t happen to her... I tell her, and at the same time I don’t know how to tell her, that she should pay attention to the boy she is going to be with, because they behave well at the beginning and then when they are in a relationship the beatings start, the mistreatment. And I feel that sometimes I don’t know how to really tell her so that she listens to me or understands me. (Mother, Dyad 4, age 43)

A few teens also reported that their parents talked about being safe and respectful when dating. One teen mentioned that his parents advised him to *“be careful. Like, know what you’re going to do, like make smart decisions. Respect the other person.”* (Male Child, Dyad 16, age 17) This teen’s mother also emphasized the importance of being respectful with his girlfriend when talking to her son. Similarly, another teen stated his parent told him *“not to abuse a woman. To treat the person right and things like that.”* (Male Child, Dyad 13, age 16) A few teens also mentioned their parents discussing the importance of patience, trust, and avoiding jealousy in a relationship. One teen said that *“probably the biggest thing that my mom tells me is like, don’t, don’t be jealous about stuff. Because it’s like, either you trust her and if you don’t, it’s just not a good situation.”* (Male Child, age 15)

One teen also mentioned having conversations with his parents about how breakups were a possibility in relationships:

They just, you know, reassured that it’s not all bad. That, that it’s okay to go to them if I have questions or

just curious to know things that could happen, before they happen. Like breakups they say could, you know, make you feel sad. They tell me about kids going through depression a lot. (Male Child, Dyad 15, age 14)

Mothers described using a variety of approaches to talk about dating and relationships. Some talked about dating and relationships in general or hypothetical terms, others discussed the teen’s current or past relationships, and a few preferred to discuss this topic within the context of their own relationships. For instance, one mother talked to her teen about the role of trust and jealousy in her life:

I was in a relationship with my partner... there was a lot of jealousy and all that. And he [teen] was observing all this, and well, when I left my partner, I explained to him that we were not doing well because there was no trust and all that. And he told me the same thing, that it was okay, that if things were not okay, he was in agreement that we should not be together. (Mother, Dyad 12, age 37)

Dating Rules and Expectations

Mothers and teens reported a mix of attitudes and rules around dating. Many mothers stated that they advised their teens to prioritize enjoying their life and not to rush into dating. While most teens reported there was no specific rule around dating, several mentioned that their parents did not want them to date right now.

The dyadic analysis revealed that five dyads agreed that their family had no specific dating rules. In three dyads, the teens reported a rule around a minimum age to date, but their mothers reported that their teen did not respect it, illustrating potential discrepancies between parental expectations and teen behaviors. Additionally, some teens reported stricter rules than their mothers reported, with one teen saying they needed to wait until they turned thirty while the mother said she had no rule. In another case, both the mother and the teen mentioned the role of the father in making this rule:

I told her... ‘It’s not a bad thing to have friends, but just try to have friends because right now... getting into a relationship takes a lot.’ I try to tell her to stop having a boyfriend because it’s one thing her dad won’t let her. (Mother, Dyad 20, age 45)

The teen noted that her mother *“told me probably [age] 15. But like, she agrees with whatever my dad says.”* (Female Child, Dyad 20, age 16)

Many teens and their mothers reported having no rules about how old they needed to be to date. One teen mentioned a desire to have more specific conversations about dating rules including, “*maybe more like the age that they’re okay with [dating]. Because I feel like even then, like, that’s still a little awkward bringing [it] up.*” (Female Child, Dyad 18, age 17) A few mothers also reported that they did not have a strict rule, but they did not want the teen to date yet.

Some mothers and teens mentioned discussing an appropriate age to start dating, which ranged from age 15 to after high school. A couple of mothers stated that teens should not date until even older ages. As one explained:

I told her she can’t date until she’s 27. I think I’m, you know, oblivious to the fact that she’s a teenager. And I think that’s just one of the hardest things for me to try to accept and that area I’m not good at. And I know that my parents were the same exact way. And parents from [this town] are the same exact way. Because, they don’t know how to talk to them about relationships and dating because they don’t expect them to be dating. (Mother, Dyad 10, age 41)

Several mothers and teens mentioned conversations about focusing on their studies rather than dating. For example, one teen stated:

Because my mom used to work in the school...she told me that a lot of times when kids are in relationships, that their grades might go down, because they’re paying more attention to the other person, or one of the people in the relationship does something bad and encourages you, just because you guys are together. (Male Child, Dyad 15, age 14)

A few mothers mentioned asking their children to tell them once they start dating so that they could better monitor the situation. One mother explained:

I always told them that when they had something like that [relationship] it is better that they tell us, that they shouldn’t be secretive because something bad can happen. So, it is better that they communicate with us and from there we know how to follow the situation. (Mother, Dyad 11, age 41)

Differences in Dating Communication and Expectations

Several teens and some of the mothers mentioned having stricter expectations with their daughters compared with

their sons when it came to dating. One teen discussed her experience with her parents’ dating rules:

Yeah, we have this rule where we have to be 15 to date and stuff like that. It’s kind of unfair cause my brother started dating at like 14...I remember in sixth grade, I think someone like one of my tios said that ‘Oh, like I saw her kissing a boy.’ It was a peck. And then [my mom] like took my phone for like three years. And then when my brother started dating, like she completely ignored the fact that he’s like, barely 14...My mom would always be like ‘It’s different. He’s a boy.’ (Female Child, Dyad 9, age 17)

Her mother similarly stated:

I feel like I’m stricter on the girls... I think it looks worse on the girls to have a lot of boyfriends and girlfriends and boyfriends. I’m sorry.... And my daughter tells me, too, like ‘Mom, you’re strict on us and my brother, he’s over here dating when he’s not supposed to be dating.’ (Mother, Dyad 9, age 35)

One of the teens reported parents being stricter with the younger siblings due to the older siblings’ behavior:

I feel like they’re a little more stricter with me and my younger sisters. Because my older sisters, they wouldn’t really notify my parents when they got boyfriends, and they would keep it to themselves. So, then my parents would find out and they’d get mad. So, I feel like they want us to be more open with them about that kind of stuff. (Female Child, Dyad 18, age 17)

Sex and Reproductive Health

About half of the mothers and teens reported having conversations about sex. Among the mothers who mentioned these discussions, a few of their teens did not report the same. The most common topics discussed were the importance of being careful, pregnancy, and contraceptive use. Participants also discussed challenges related to these discussions as well as the role of religion and culture.

Pregnancy and Contraceptive Use

Nearly all who reported conversations about sex discussed pregnancy, particularly the consequences of an unintended pregnancy and having a baby as a teen. While one mother reported that she informed her teen that she would support

them if they experienced an unintended pregnancy, several others focused on the negative consequences including needing to get married early. As one mother shared:

I tell my son to behave himself, to be careful because look, if you have a girlfriend ... many things happen when there are many changes. I tell them, if you get married at a very young age, you are going to lock yourself and her up. Because when you have a baby, I tell him, it's over, all the going out, the streets, the dances, and everything. I am not going to be taking care of babies just because you are going to a dance. (Mother, Dyad 13, age 52)

About one third of mothers and a few teens reported discussions about “being careful” about sex, particularly as it related to pregnancy and STIs. One mother stated:

I trust her judgment. I trust a lot that we have talked about it. Every day, I think almost every day if not every other day or something like that, we bring it up. 'Be careful, you know, be smart, make good decisions.' But I'm very afraid somebody will take advantage of her, things like that. The possibility that she will have unprotected sex and an unwanted pregnancy, I think those are some of the biggest concerns for me as a mom. (Mother, Dyad 8, age 38)

A few teens and several mothers reported talking about contraceptive methods. When discussing sex, one teen stated their mother “told me to just stay away from it, but if I don't do that, to use protection.” (Female Child, Dyad 4, age 14) Over half of mothers reported discussing STIs with their teens, while a few teens also reported this. One teen explained that their parents discussed “condoms... it doesn't matter if the other person tells you to not use it, like you gotta use it. Because you never know, if they have like HIV or something like that.” (Male Child, Dyad 5, age 16) His mother similarly reported:

I get involved because their dad doesn't take the initiative to talk with them... I talk about sex, I give them condoms, I tell them, 'Look, be careful.' (Mother, Dyad 5, age 40)

Related Topics

Several mothers reported discussing the need to respect women and oneself in sexual decision-making. A few mothers discussed the importance of waiting to have sex with someone you like, respect, and who likes you back. As one mother stated:

I never set an age for them [to have sex]. I've always told them when they're ready.... My son also said, 'At what age can I have sex?' I said, 'It's not the age, but it's... the person you're with and the mindset, the mindset that you have.' Because he says, 'Do I have to wait until I'm married?' and I said, 'Not necessarily.' I said, '... your first time should be with someone you respect and love. Not like one night with one and another night with another.' I tell him, 'It has to be with the right person and that you both want it.' I tell him... 'Never force anyone to do something they don't want to do.' (Mother, Dyad 16, age 48)

A few mothers also discussed the legal consequences of consent. As one explained:

I tell them that at their age, there are consequences if they touch a girl or if they talk to her about other things, and they should not do it. And I always tell them that this is a very difficult issue in which there are very serious consequences, and not only that she could get pregnant, but that they could even go to jail. (Mother, Dyad 3, age 36)

Topics rarely discussed included sexual assault, abortion, and masturbation.

Challenges Related to Communication about Sex

About half of the mothers reported conversations about sex as being stressful or difficult, while only a few felt that these conversations were not difficult. Several teens also mentioned these conversations being stressful and awkward. While almost half of the mothers reported only discussing sex briefly, a third said they did not avoid these topics and were open to discussing anything with their teens. A few teens also reported only having one-time conversations. When asked about discussing sex with parents, one teen stated:

Kind of? Not much... my mom just asked me about when I was having the sex ed class, and I told her, we have barely had it, and then I don't know, it was like quick. I think that's like the only time. (Male Child, Dyad 7, age 15)

A few mothers stated that they should discuss the topics more often than they currently do. However, a third of the mothers felt that they did not have the right words and mentioned that they had not discussed these topics with their own parents. A few mothers believed their teens already knew more about sexual health than they did, which made it more difficult for them to initiate these conversations. This was particularly true with technology and

information being more accessible to teens. Only one mother felt positive about this development:

I said, 'You could Google all the images and stuff like that for all the sexual transmitted diseases. So, I don't even have to tell you, you just Google it and look at all the pictures, and you guys don't want to have one of those.' (Mother, Dyad 9, age 35)

Several mothers reported that their teens did not want to talk to them about sex. A few mothers and one teen mentioned embarrassment as a challenge to discussing sex. A couple of mothers shared how having a conversation with a teen who was the opposite gender to them made it harder to have these conversations.

A few teens discussed how a history of teen pregnancy in the family made it challenging to discuss dating or sex. For example, one teen discussed the impact of her mother's teen pregnancy:

I feel like, I can't really be myself because they compare me to themselves a lot. Because my mom, she got pregnant at a young age, and she's scared of that happening to me, but I know within myself that I'm not doing that. (Female Child, Dyad 8, Age 15)

In contrast, this teen's mother felt that telling her daughter about the difficult experience of being a teen mother brought them closer together:

She was very moved. We hugged, we cried, because I spoke to her.... I think I have always talked to her about my life, but not so openly...I simply told her, 'If I could open my heart, I would show it to you and tell you whatever I wanted to spare you...but I want you to wait.' ... She fell in love, and I tell her, 'You are still very immature, and you have to give yourself time.' (Mother, Dyad 8, Age 38)

Cultural and Religious Influences

Some mothers discussed how cultural and religious norms can make these topics taboo. A couple of teens also discussed the impact of cultural influences and gendered norms. As one teen stated:

They talk about like, you shouldn't [have sex]. Like that's something that is disrespectful to the body, to the woman's body. And like they kind of make it sound like bad, I don't know, they make it sound like, it's just completely bad. Like you're a bad person if you do sex before marriage or anything like that... because

what they see is, it's not your body. It's God's body. Like, he's the one that made your body and it's disrespectful to him. They had brought up that like, it's not you, you could say like, my body my choice, but it's not your body. (Female Child, Dyad 8, age 15)

However, a few mothers also talked about how these traditional norms are changing with newer generations, particularly as families adapt to cultural expectations in the U.S. As one mother shared:

We were really raised in a different way. But now in this country, it's like everything is freer. Topics are already discussed differently, and we have even gone to [a sex ed] workshop. (Mother, Dyad 3, age 36)

Strategies for Communication about Sex

Many mothers discussed using specific strategies to broach the subject of sex with their teens. The most common strategy, mentioned by a third of mothers, was to discuss the consequences of early pregnancy on the teen's educational and professional dreams. Several of the mothers discussed using cases in the community or their families to initiate conversations. One shared a conversation she had with her teen:

I told her that a little while ago a girl got pregnant and how old she was, right? And I told her that if she makes that same mistake, she should tell me about it, but she should try not to do things that she might regret later. I mean, how is it that one child is going to be taking care of another child? (Mother, Dyad 4, age 43)

A couple of mothers reported using humor as a strategy to have conversations about sexual health. Others discussed using books and health literature to help with conversations, and some mothers also used sexual education courses and parent workshops as a starting point for the conversations. One mother stated:

The day that we attended the workshop at her high school, I talked to her about what they said about the questions that the young people asked anonymously and more than anything else, I told her that sometimes it is because of the same distrust that we [parents] have of them that we don't talk to them. And sometimes it is also good to have these meetings for the parents as well as for them [teens], so that they can ask questions, it doesn't matter if they are anonymous, but so that they can develop or learn more things. (Mother, Dyad 17, age 38)

Table 2 Recommendations from Mothers and Teens to improve communication

Mothers' Recommendations	Teens' Recommendations
• Parents need to be open with teens and give them space to share. Conversations are uncomfortable but important to have. • Teens should trust and confide in parents over their friends. • Sex education should be offered more frequently. • Offer parent-teen sex education workshops. • Provide parents with information on sexual health, having conversations about sensitive topics, and how to build trust between parents and teens.	• Parents need to actively listen, be understanding, and have an open mind. • Have more in-depth conversations about dating and relationships. • Parents should not focus only on the negatives, but also positives of dating and sex. • Parent should not judge or chastise. • Parents should be less awkward and make teens feel comfortable. • Parents should pick the right moment, have one-on-one conversations, and set the stage. • Parents should increase the frequency of conversations. • Parents and teens should have a good baseline relationship. • Parents should just answer the questions being asked. • Parents need more information on STIs.

Several mothers relied on other family members to talk to their teens about sex and contraception. In some cases, this was done because of parental embarrassment around the topic and, in others, out of a personal preference from the teen to talk to someone other than their parent. One mother stated:

I have always been a person who has told them that they can come talk to me... I don't shy away from things. I told them, if you want to talk about sex, if you want to talk about drugs, if you want to talk about whatever, they always know they can talk to me. But I find that sometimes they feel more comfortable [with other family members] I have a lot of family that supports me, so sometimes he will go talk to my sister, because she works at the high school and ...she's younger than me. (Mother, Dyad 16, age 48)

Knowledge Gaps and Informational Needs

Mothers were asked whether they felt they had enough information about sexual health, while teens were asked whether they believed their parents had enough information. While most of the teens thought their parents had enough information, many of the mothers thought they did not or would like more. Of the five dyads where mothers said they did not have information, four of their children thought they did. A few teens mentioned that their parents needed more information about STIs. One teen discussed how “*some parents will just say, oh, like, ‘You need to prevent infections,’ but they don’t really go in depth about what infections. They don’t talk about AIDS, HIV, or, like, they don’t talk a lot about that.*” (Female Child, Dyad 11, age 19)

Half of the mothers reported that they had basic knowledge about sex and sexual health but would like more in-depth information. Several stated that they did not have enough sexual health information, and some

discussed the need to understand the impact of generational changes, technology, and social media. One mother stated:

We need more information. I feel like you never have enough... I’m trying to find out how the generations have changed, or how kids have changed. Because all this social media and all these things have, I feel like kids know more about it. But they feel like they know everything now. (Mother, Dyad 9, age 35)

One mother discussed how the internet is an important source of information, and the challenges around health literacy among parents in rural areas:

I do think about like our families, especially here in the rural area that don’t have or don’t even know how to like, navigate the Internet ... I feel like the lack of literacy around my community does exist. (Mother, Dyad 19, age 38)

Recommendations from Parents and Teens

Mothers and teens were asked to provide specific recommendations for how communication around sex and dating can be improved. The most frequent recommendations were for parents to actively listen, be understanding, and have an open mind. See Table 2.

About a third of teens mentioned the importance of parents actively listening and understanding them when talking about dating and relationships or sex. As one teen said, “*just listen [to] what their kids have to say first, and then let the kids talk to their parents about what’s going on peacefully, and then [determine] if the parents can fix it then or help out then.*” (Male Child, Dyad 16, age 17)

Similarly, one teen reported the significance of parents keeping an open mind:

Like being more open to like, listening... like, 'If you're gonna have a boyfriend, like, I'm gonna listen, but you also have to listen to me, to my rules.' Like, there's gonna be limits to each thing. (Female Child, Dyad 18, age 17)

Some mothers mirrored this recommendation of being more open with teens and giving them the space to share.

Several teens mentioned the importance of their parents being non-judgmental and not immediately bringing the negative consequences of dating and sex into the discussion. One teen recommended *"not to start saying, 'Oh, no, don't, don't be doing nasty stuff.' Because then at that point you're just making [the children] uncomfortable."* (Male Child, Dyad 12, age 14) Several teens mentioned that parents should not judge or chastise their teens for discussing dating and relationships and discussed getting in trouble or being judged after these conversations. One recommended that parents should *"not be too harsh on their kids. If the kid wants to talk about sensitive topics like that, to not jump ahead and skip to a specific topic, to be more open with their kids."* (Female Child, Dyad 10, age 13) Relatedly, this teen's mother mentioned this openness and non-judgmental attitude as being bi-directional:

Yeah, I think just the willingness to be open about it. So, to hear different perspectives, but I think that can be said for both [parents and teens]. One of the biggest challenges is that, you know, you tend to not want to listen to a different perspective or a different take on something. So, I think for teenagers, it's that willingness to be open and to accept, you know, without criticizing or without judging, you know, a parent's point of view on something. (Mother, Dyad 10 age 41)

A few teens suggested that parents make the children feel more comfortable by picking the right moment, setting the stage, and having one-on-one conversations. One teen recommended, *"to have the right time or moment to talk to their children about it. To not make them uncomfortable when talking about the topic."* (Female Child, Dyad 1, age 14) Similarly, a couple of mothers felt that, although these conversations are uncomfortable, they are important to have. One mother discussed the importance of parents not shying away from difficult conversations:

This is something for their own good, or if we want to have these conversations with them, it is because we care about them and because we want a good quality life for them, and to prepare them with good intentions. In other words, these are uncomfortable [conversations], but it's to protect their lives, so that

they do not live with negative consequences that they should not have to endure. (Mother, Dyad 7, age 33)

While most teens said there were no topics they wanted to discuss further with their parents, a few teens suggested that parents increase communication and check in more about teen's experiences with dating, relationships, and sex. One teen advised to just *"try to talk to me or, like, ask me questions."* (Female Child, Dyad 17, age 17) Another teen suggested that communication would improve if parents talked about their own experiences with relationships. Similarly, some mothers felt that teens should trust and confide in their parents more often. A few mothers also stated that teens should trust and confide in their parents over their friends.

Some of the other recommendations mentioned by teens included the importance of a good baseline relationship between teens and parents and reminding teens that parents are there for them. A few teens also stated that parents should *"just answer off the questions that they are being asked."* (Male Child, Dyad 15, age 14) One teen also suggested having gendered conversations and stated, *"I feel like if it's a girl, I feel like a mom should talk to her, or like, if it's a boy, it'll be easier if a dad talks to him."* (Female Child, Dyad 11, age 19).

Some mothers recommended different options for additional information for parents and teens. A few suggested offering sex education more frequently or one-on-one; some mothers also recommended having parent-teen sex education workshops. Finally, a couple of mothers expressed their desire for more information on sexual health and how to build trust between parents and teens. One mother proposed *"that they hold health fairs for girls and boys to go to, because I know that not all parents are comfortable talking to them [teens], but maybe they will listen to other people that are not their parents."* (Mother, Dyad 13, age 52).

Discussion

This study highlights the complex interplay of factors that shape mother-teen communication in rural Latino families including at the macro, micro, and chronosystem. At the micro or family level, most mothers and teens reported communicating about dating and relationships, which is similar to research conducted by Romo & Hurtado (Romo & Hurtado, 2022) and may reflect an increase in this type of conversations among Latino families (Lantos et al., 2019). However, conversations about sex and sexual health were less common and many considered these discussions to be stressful and difficult.

Our findings further highlight the importance of the chronosystem, or generational experiences and changes in

attitudes over time, in interpersonal communication (Bronfenbrenner, 1976). Mothers' previous experiences within their own families and adolescence, though varied in the sample, shaped the way they approached these sensitive conversations with their teens. Some mothers discussed not having the right words or ability to initiate conversations as their own parents did not have these conversations with them. Others mentioned past experiences with abusive relationships, which may affect their own approaches to these conversations, making them more vigilant about dating safety. In addition, mothers who had teen pregnancies were more inclined to be protective and proactive when discussing sex and contraception with their teen daughters. To date, limited research has explored the role of intergenerational experiences or the impact of a mother's teen pregnancy on their approach to these conversations (Grossman et al., 2015, 2016). Importantly, the mothers in this sample were motivated to change these norms and were interested in gaining more information to improve these conversations.

While some participants discussed the role of culture and religion, traditional gender norms appeared to be the most common issue at this macro level. This study found some differences in communication based on the gender of the teen or the gender of the parent. Several teens reported that their parents were less strict with dating rules for the boys in their family, with girls expressing frustration with these rules and double standards. This is similar to previous research in many cultures, including in Latino immigrant communities, that show the influence of gender norms on communication (Alcalde & Quelopana, 2013; Kapungu et al., 2010; Lantos et al., 2019; Stauss et al., 2011). Families should consider their potential biases when establishing rules to foster better communication and build trust with their children.

Other community-level factors affecting communication around these topics include the role of schools, health services, and rurality. A few participants discussed how living in rural areas influences their conversations about sex, as well as limited access to sexual health information and services for both teens and adults. The role of stigma in rural areas may create barriers to both sensitive conversations and accessing health services (Valentine et al., 2022). Engaging parents in learning about medically accurate information and practicing active communication skills may benefit both parents and their children. The mothers and teens in our study were open to having discussions about these topics and would like support in accessing information and generating positive communication strategies. There is some evidence for the effectiveness of programs that address parent-teen communication, including one that found increased

communication and reduced unprotected sex and unintended pregnancies among participating youth in rural communities (Brown et al., 2021). As several mothers suggested holding educational workshops and sessions in the community, future programs should consider developing culturally relevant programming for predominantly immigrant rural communities. More broadly, there is a considerable need for training programs, tools, materials, and other supports to enhance parents' knowledge, develop communication skills, and promote positive attitudes about adolescent sexual health and development. Moreover, research has found that most parents support the inclusion of age-appropriate sex education classes in schools (Yeo & Lee, 2020). While increasing health literacy is crucial, improving access to services and other resources that are often more limited in rural communities is also needed.

Some of our mother-teen dyads reported different levels of satisfaction and perceptions about these conversations in part due to differences in expectations and generational dynamics. This finding supports previous research that suggests that parents and teens may incongruently recall conversations about sex (Akers et al., 2011; Gabbidon & Shaw-Ridley, 2018). Teens were motivated to enhance their communication with their parents and provided valuable suggestions for improvement. Teens appreciated their parents being open, honest, and non-judgmental when talking to them about sex. Some teens mentioned how they hesitated to discuss their dating lives with their parents because they feared their parents would be critical. The most common recommendation by teen participants was to prioritize active listening. Consistent with prior research, a few teens also recommended discussing the positive aspects of dating and sex into the conversation rather than solely focusing on negative aspects (Pariera & Brody, 2018).

Findings from this study highlight the need for programs and policy initiatives that support parents in fostering open and effective conversations with their teens about sex, dating, and relationships. Policy efforts should integrate family communication support into existing public health and education initiatives. By embedding parent-focused communication strategies into education initiatives and policies, institutions may help foster improved parent-teen dialogue about relationships and sexual health. Other efforts at increasing communication around these sensitive topics may reduce stigma at the broader community level. For example, policies should aim to expand clinical services (e.g., through telehealth or mobile health clinics) and comprehensive sexual health education to increase awareness of and access to information and services for teens and their families.

Limitations

This study had limitations that warrant attention. Because research is limited on the role of fathers in parent-child communication, we deliberately sought to recruit fathers into the study. However, we only located one father willing to be interviewed, limiting the results to the experiences of mother-teen dyads and further highlighting the need to prioritize fathers in future research and engagement in these discussions (Coleman-Minahan et al., 2020; Estrada-Martínez et al., 2021). Additionally, many participants were recruited at community events through an existing program which provides health education for students and parents/caregivers. These participants may be more involved and motivated to discuss sensitive topics with their teens. As a result, our participants may not be representative of other parents/caregivers, limiting the generalizability of the findings even within these rural communities. Although we conducted interviews in both Spanish and English, following participants' preferences, we note the lack of language diversity in the area of parent/teen communication research and hope to see a greater diversity of studies in the future. Additionally, we did not compare the responses of the adolescents by gender, which warrants additional research to more fully understand differences in communication experiences, dynamics and preferences within families. Finally, while the participants reported which topics related to sexual health they had discussed, we note that the depth, quality, and accuracy of the conversations was not assessed.

Conclusion

This study of Latino mothers and teens in rural communities found that discussions about sex and dating were occurring, including conversations about healthy relationships, pregnancy, and contraception. Mothers showed substantial interest and commitment to provide their teens with relevant information to support their health and wellbeing. Similarly, teens expressed openness to having these conversations with their parents and valued conversations that consider both positive and negative aspects about sex and dating and that are informative, open, and non-judgmental. This study highlights the limited tools available in rural settings to have these conversations. Programs and policies can support parents and teens by incorporating opportunities to talk about intergenerational and cultural influences, gender norms, and positive communication strategies.

Data Availability

Interview transcripts are available upon request from the corresponding author.

Supplementary information The online version contains supplementary material available at <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10826-025-03105-z>.

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Compliance with Ethical Standards

Conflict of Interest The authors declare no competing interests.

Ethics Approval The study protocol and materials were approved by the Institutional Review Board for the Human Research Protection Program of the University of California, San Francisco approval # 20-32633.

Informed Consent Informed consent was obtained from all individual participants included in the study.

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